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austin updates episode 2 (january/beginning of february)

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what's up y'all

On new year's eve i was throwing out a lot of old things from my childhood bedroom while talking on the phone with a friend. Cleaning my childhood room had me feeling like a full-fledged adult. Throwing away dusty participation trophies, donating books i'd got from the Christian bookstore at 13, filing away papers from college in neat boxes. In some old school papers, i just happened to find a printed-out PDF of an essay titled "New Years Eve." You know when the memory of something is lodged like a pebble in the folds of your brain? When you can feel you remember something but don't actually remember it? That's how it was with this essay. I felt the memory of someone i care about giving it to me, but i couldn't remember who it was.

The essay gave expression to the more unsettling parts of New Year's. Like birthdays, New Year's can sometimes feel more like a reminder of the passage of time and the loss of the person you were in the past than anything else.

Every year my mom squeals the last ten seconds to midnight; "here we go, here we go" she says, "Ten, nine, eight..." She stands in the center of the living room, and at zero, she shouts "Happy New Year!" and goes around to hug everyone. As i've gotten older, i've found it harder to face the new year (and the passing of the old one) with such fearless joy. So i'm a little grateful to that essay, and more so to that acquaintance of a year past, for helping put words to these feelings.

The new year proper began with a book club meeting. We hadn't met for a few weeks, so discussed two books, *The History of Love* by Nicole Krauss and *Greek Lessons* by Han Kang. We must've talked for two hours, but the time flew and it was fabulous to hear how everyone's doing and to talk books together. *Greek Lessons* was really good.

The new year also began with the latter half of a recording of Hanif Abdurraqib's SF stop of his book tour. I listened to the first half the day before on my run, and finished it on my run on New Year's Day. A lot of things stuck from this talk. On tour, one thing he did to ground himself was call friends on the West Coast and make up a story on the spot to put their kids to sleep to. Or if the kids were in bed already, he'd ask the friend what the best part of their day was. I hope one day i'll have the self-awareness and wisdom to take care of myself with such creative and tender practices. He spoke, too, about how, with writers like Mary Oliver and Ross Gay, what people misunderstand about them is that they are saying, first and foremost, *you will die*. They say that, and then they invite you, *but look at this flower*, or, *see how the sky today is bluer than yesterday*. Hanif said if he wrote books trying to get people to like his interests, 1) he'd fail, and 2) the books would be far too long. What he aims to do, instead, is invite someone into the miracle of both being able to witness something together (i'm butchering this, but that's what i remember).

TOP 5 NOVELS I READ IN 2024 IN NO PARTICULAR ORDER:

Morrison, *Song of Solomon*

Ursula Le Guin, *The Dispossessed*

Han Kang, *Human Acts*

W.G. Sebald, *The Rings of Saturn* (really was 2023 but oh well)

Claire Keegan, *Small Things Like These*

Thinking about the reasons i began this “newsletter,” one that comes up is a slight dissatisfaction with journaling. I’ve kept a journal to varying degrees of dailiness for the past five years. But i am terrible about going back and reading them. If it’s not painful to do so it’s a chore. In my bookshelf in Arkansas i have the last 4 years of journals. Maybe there’s a time in the future when i’ll go back and review them all, but it hasn’t come yet. If you journal, how do you make sure what you write doesn’t just disappear into the pages, or do you care? Does reading your old journals feel painful? Anyway, the blog/newsletter feels like a more easily reflective form.

I’m writing the second half of this email from Korea—i’ve been here for about three/four weeks now. I’ll be here for a year with Fulbright, i think most of y’all knew that but i’m not sure. For these past weeks, i’ve been at Jungwon University, in a town of nine thousand called Goesan-eup. The food is fire, it snowed last week, and i’ve met a lotta homies.



me with a fish at the hwacheon ice fishing festival



homies in the elevator

There's a lot that's new here. If y'all have specific questions you should ask! I'll just talk about a few things though, for now.

I feel i've gotten more active since moving here. Like this is the most active i've been in my life. One friend i've made is training for the Seoul marathon in March, and she didn't wanna do long runs alone so i tagged along. The first long run was nine miles—the longest i'd ran in my life—and it unlocked something. Goesan has a river and there's a wildly nice trail that follows it.



the trail and a bunch of cranes(?) in the river

When we run, we run down to the trail and take it out into the countryside. There are lots of farms, lots of Hyundai Porter IIs, and lots of chill wooden pagoda things. I really do enjoy the cold and the long runs and the mountains. Last weekend her, another friend and I did 10 miles. It was really really fun. I'm lowkey planning now to do a half this year, maybe even a full marathon in the fall.

Here at the university, we also have access to a gym on weekdays from 7-10, and i've been going a lot. Another friend is the cohort's resident gym god, and she's really kind and answers all of our form and workout questions, so i feel i've been improving a lot.

Yesterday we had the placement ceremony. The homies are scattered around, but not too scattered—we're all kinda central/southeast, and ~2 hours from each other. I'll be in a city called Gyeongsan, on the outskirts of Daegu. I don't know yet if i'll be living with a family in a homestay or if i'll have my own apartment yet, but for y'all who wanna visit, start plotting SOON.

Also, i've been back on my coffee grind again. In the mornings i usually go to the convenient store on campus and get an americano. We're so back.

Things I'm reading/watching/listening to:

- Eusexua, FKA Twigs
 - o I don't need to say anything i think...unalloyed fire. "Perfect stranger" is my favorite track.
- *DeBí TiRAR MaS FOToS*, Bad Bunny
 - o Best new Bad Bunny in a minute—has been really good to listen to in the gym/running (along -w- the Twigs).
- *Beware of Pity*, Stefan Zweig (1939)

- We started a kinda book club and this is the book we're reading. I might not have picked it up on my own, but i'm really liking it. The novel examines pity and how it underpin/undermine relationships. An officer in the Austrian army gets drawn into the orbit of a wealthy household by his pity for the daughter, who is partially paralyzed from the waist down. The start of the book's epigraph goes hard: "There are two kinds of pity. One, the weak and sentimental kind, which is really no more than the heart's impatience to be rid as quickly as possible of the painful emotion aroused by the sight of another's unhappiness..." I feel the book's reflections on pity apply to a lot of contexts, but in particular it's making me reflect (and showing me more clearly?) the ways in which pity has moved in my own prior romantic relationships...
- *The Life of Nuns*, Henrike Lähnemann
 - Still working on this—have been taking a break since starting *Beware of Pity*.
- "Ursula Le Guin's Anarchist Alternative" Anarres Project (Spotify)
 - I listened to this two times through across a couple runs, and it has me thinking more about anarchism. The first anarchist i ever knew was Moira Fradinger, who taught Radical Cinemas of Latin America, the best course i took at Y*le probably. S/o Gracie for sharing.

Want to say thank you to everyone who has responded to the last email. It was wonderful reading all of y'all's responses. Also sorry this email is coming out a bit late. Between the ~5 hours/day of language study and random-ass orientation workshops time has been a little short. I leave Goesan for my placement in a few weeks, and after settling in expect things to get a bit more routine.

keep moving
austin